

Pathet Lao Takeover

The American withdrawal from Vietnam in 1973 and the subsequent communist victory gave a boost to the Pathet Lao, who had won control of large areas of their country.

◀◀ BEFORE

The battle against North Vietnamese forces in Laos and along the Ho Chi Minh Trail made that country a crucial theater in the war in Indochina.

DIVIDED COUNTRY

Following the 1954 Geneva Conference, the Pathet Lao established control in two northern provinces. A coalition government between Royalists and communists collapsed in 1959 and a **long civil war** ensued.

In an attempt to disrupt the Ho Chi Minh Trail, the US bombed Laos extensively and organized and funded a **clandestine army of Hmong people** to operate against the North Vietnamese.

The US exit from Vietnam affected all of Indochina. In February 1973, the Pathet Lao and the Royal Laotian Government signed a ceasefire—the Vientiane Treaty—but the Pathet Lao did not disarm and the NVA remained in the country. With the communist takeovers in Phnom Penh and Saigon in April 1975, the Pathet Lao stepped up attacks on the Royalist forces.

The prime minister Souvanna Phouma knew that his forces could not prevail against this assault. He had little choice but to accept a promise of moderation from the leader of the Pathet Lao, his half-brother Prince Souphanouvong, and invite the communists to participate in a coalition government.

On August 23, 1975, 50 Pathet Lao troops entered Vientiane, the capital city, claiming to “liberate” it. Over the ensuing months the communists extended their control to the rest of the country.

Coalition collapses

For a few months the Pathet Lao cooperated with the Royalists in the government. Souvanna Phouma ordered the Royalist military forces not to oppose the Pathet Lao. The US cut off economic aid, but maintained a diplomatic presence. However, on December 2, 1975, the Pathet Lao moved to take full power. They swept aside the noncommunist members of the coalition, forced King Savang Vatthana to abdicate, and abolished the monarchy. The king and the royal family were sent to a brutal re-education camp in November 1976 and all died within the next two years. The regime broke economic relations with China, while Soviet and other Eastern bloc countries provided economic aid. The newly proclaimed Lao People’s Democratic Republic signed a treaty with the Socialist Republic of Vietnam that allowed Vietnam to appoint advisers to help oversee the country and to station armed forces there. The US withdrew entirely and Laos fell almost totally under Vietnamese hegemony.